



HE SHALL NOT EAT WHO DOES NOT WORK

THE RUSSIAN CONSTITUTION (1918)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Constitutional law

BEFORE

1791 In France, revolutionaries proclaim a new constitution.

1871 The Paris Commune—based on radical, socialist ideals—rules the city briefly, for 3 months.

1905 The Russian Revolution leads to a new constitution and an elected legislature, the State Duma.

AFTER

1924 The 1918 Constitution is revised to consolidate the power of the Russian Communist Party (which later becomes the Communist Party of the Soviet Union).

1936 The Stalin Constitution gives total control to Stalin and the Communist Party.

1991 The Soviet Union (USSR) is dissolved, and with it the Communist Constitution.

The **revolution of the proletariat**, the working class, must **survive**.



The **bourgeoisie** will do anything to **overturn the revolution**.



The proletariat masses are **too fickle to sustain the changes** needed.



The **revolutionary leaders** of the proletariat must **take firm control**.



The constitution adopts a blueprint for society and excludes the bourgeoisie.

In 1917, during the February Revolution, Russian soldiers weary of World War I drove Czar Nicholas II from St. Petersburg to clear the way for a provisional government. Following the czar's abdication in March, liberals had hoped to see a move toward representative democracy. However, a failed attempt in September by imperial Russian general Lavr Kornilov to overthrow the provisional government provoked Vladimir Lenin, who was then in exile in Finland, to rally his Bolshevik followers.

Bolshevik takeover

Lenin decided the time was right for his return to Russia, where he would play a leading role in the October Revolution. Influenced by German founder of communism Karl Marx, Lenin embraced the idea of the "dictatorship of the proletariat," so called because the power of the proletariat, or working class, should not be limited by laws created by the bourgeoisie.

On October 25 (November 7, Gregorian calendar), the Bolsheviks seized power and quickly formed both the Red Army and the Cheka—ruthless enforcers who went on to